Advanced & Post Reading Material (APRM)
EPP-II 2025-26 GLA University, Mathura
Module-I (Verbal Ability)

Prepositions

"The plane flew above the cloud, behind the cloud, around the cloud, below the cloud, beneath the cloud, beside the cloud, beyond the cloud, into the cloud, near the cloud, outside the cloud, over the cloud, past the cloud, through the cloud, towards the cloud, under the cloud, and finally dived underneath the cloud."

Definition

A preposition is a word that shows the relationship between two entities. In the example above, the prepositions show the relationships between a plane and a cloud.

A preposition is usually followed by a noun or noun phrase which is the object of the preposition. It also shows its relation to some other word in the sentence. Look at the following sentences:
1. There is no sugar *in* the pot.
2. He is coming *by* plane.
3. Rama is very angry *with* you.

In the first sentence '*in'* shows the relation between *sugar* and *pot (*both nouns*)*.
In the second '*by'* shows the relation between coming (verb) and plane (noun).
In the last sentence '*with'* shows the relation between angry (adjective) and you (pronoun).
In, by and *with* are examples of prepositions.

Commonly used prepositions: in, into, on, onto, to, towards, by, within, for, from, off, on, out, through, till, up, down, above, across, among, behind, between, since and many others.

Use of Preposition

Generally, prepositions are used before their objects (table, office, tea, Delhi). For Example:
(i) The book is on the table.
(ii) He is in his office.
(iii) She comes from Delhi.

In the above sentences *on, in, from* are prepositions. A preposition may have two or more than two objects. The preposition will be used before the first of all these objects. For Example:
(i) The cattle graze in valleys and pastures.
(ii) She is very fond of grapes, apples and oranges.

Rule 1: Use of preposition at the end of the sentence

(A) When the object is Relative Pronoun 'that', 'then' the preposition is placed at the end of the sentence.

Also note that End-position prepositions are common and natural in spoken English.

For Example:
(i) This is the book that you were searching for.
(ii) That is the car that you travelled by.
(iii) I know the man that you are talking to.
(iv) To whom are you speaking? (Formal)
(v) Who are you speaking to? (Neutral)

(B) Also, when the object is understood somewhat (hidden) Relative Pronoun. The preposition is placed at the end of the sentence. For Example:
(i) That is the man (whom) I was talking of.
(ii) There is the book (that) you are looking for.

(C) When the object is an Interrogative Pronoun (who / whom / which / what). The preposition is placed at the end of the sentence. Who is common in conversation; Whom is formal and less frequent. For example:
(i) Whom are you going with? (Common English)
(ii) With whom are you going? (Formal)
(ii) Which of these houses do you live in?

Rule 2: Omission of preposition

(A) Before certain expressions of time and place, **no preposition is used**. For example:

(i) I came here last week. ('In last week 'is wrong)

(ii) I am going abroad. ("going for abroad is wrong")

(B) When some expressions of time (such as morning, evening, day, night, month, year, etc.) have some qualifying words such as this, that, next, every, last, all used before them, no preposition is used.

For Example:
(i) He went this morning
(ii) He met me last evening.
(iii) He is coming again next week.

Note: But if these expressions of time do not have qualifying words before them, a preposition is used. For Example:

(i) He went in the morning.

(ii) He met me in the evening.

(C) If two verbs are used in the sentence and both the verbs have to take different prepositions, we must use appropriate preposition for each verb separately. For Example:
(i) I have been thinking about and waiting for you since morning.
(ii) He has been looking for and enquiring about you for a long time.

(D) Verbs that typically do not take a preposition before the object: discuss, request, inform, accompany, resemble, resist, attack, enter, marry, await, approach, investigate. Do not add extra prepositions like discuss about, marry with, enter into with the given point. For Example:

(i) America attacked Iraq. (no 'on')

(ii) I will await your instruction. (no 'for')

(iii) I shall assist you. (no 'to')

Preposition of Place: in, at, on, into

In denotes a state of being inside something, whereas into indicates movement to the inside of something.
(a) She is in the class.
(b) He fell into the well.
(c) He came into the room

We use 'In' for *a road, a street, a room and any other enclosed space. (physical or imagined boundary)*

(a) Nikita lives in Victoria Street.

(b) Manisha was sleeping in the garden.

In, At

In is also used when referring to large place as countries, state, districts, large cities etc., while 'at' is generally used in small places such as villages, small towns etc., or a point of place.

(a) He lives at Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu.

(b) But his brother lives in Delhi.

At

At is used when the function of the building or place is referred to describe a position.

(a) We met him at the bus stop/ at the railway station.

At is also used for a house or an address.

(b) He lives at 32, Lower Circular Road.

(c) We were at home in the evening.

On, Onto

On is used to state the position on a surface. Onto indicates meaning which refers to the movement to a surface .

(a) We pasted the notice on the board.

(b) We got onto the bus.

To, Towards

To indicates movement towards some building, place, country etc.

Towards signifies movement in a particular direction of something or somebody.

(a) She drove to the airport with her father.

(b) I have been to Australia twice.

(c) He is going to Church.

(d) He is walking towards the Church.

Above and Over

Above means higher than (not necessarily touching/covering) on the other hand over means vertically above and, it indicates covering, across or movement thus it indicates *nearness.*

(a) The plane is flying above the clouds.

(b) A blanket is over him. (covering)

(c) The plane flew over the city. (across)

Between, Among

Between is used when you refer to:

1. two persons or things

(a) I have to choose *between* these two pictures.

(b) I stood *between* Rahul and Ravi.

2. Any two large numbers

(a) He walked across the park *between* the flower beds.

(b) They marched up the aisle *between* the pillars.

Among is used with more than two people or things

(a) The British were able to conquer India because the Indian princes quarreled among themselves.

(b) The United Nations tries to maintain peace among the nations of the world.

Between relates to the position of a person / thing to two other persons/ things. However, it can also be used if we have a definite number in mind.

(a) Flora is standing between Smita and Anshi.

Among relates to the position of a person thing to more than two persons, things, when we do not have any definite number in mind.

Our flat is biggest among all the flats in the building

Around/ Round

Around refers the meaning of *in the area of or in various positions.* Round refers to a *circular motion or position around another object.*

(a) The children were running around the building.

(b) The earth revolves round the sun.

Across, Through

Across is used to state the movement from one side to other side.

(a) He drove the car across the road.

Through states the meaning of movement between things.

(b) The bullet went through the window.

(c) The gateway was so narrow that the truck could not get through it.

Beside, Besides

Beside means *by the side of* and besides means *in addition to*.

(a) The house was beside the river. (by the side of the river)

(b) Besides football, he also plays basketball.

Preposition of time

At, On, In, By

'At' indicates exact point of time as at 5 o' clock, at 9: 30, at midnight.

'At' is also used with festivals like *at Christmas, at Dussehra at Deepawali etc.*

(a) We will have a meeting at five o' clock.

(b) We shall discuss it at breakfast.

(c) They are going to have a party at Deepawali.

'On' is used with a more general point of time as *days of the week, dates and parts of the day.*

(a) He gave us a test on Wednesday.

(b) His birthday falls on 18 May.

(c) I visited her on Friday.

'In' is used with *months, years, seasons, centuries, and parts of the day.*

(a) The election will be held in February.

(b) We have a long vacation in summer.

(c) Many countries became industrialized in the twentieth century.

'By' is used to express time not later than.

(a) We will reach your house by 5 o' clock. (at 5 or earlier)

By is also used to show the latest time at which an action will be finished, so it is usually used with the future tense.

(a) I shall be leaving by 6 o' clock.

(b) I hope to finish the work by New Year's Day.

In, Within

With reference to time, in means *at the end of* a certain period, whereas *within* means *before the end of* a certain period.

(a) The spaceship will reach the moon in three days. (at the end of three days)

(b) The spaceship will reach the moon *within* three days. (before the end of three days)

(c) The loan will be paid in a year.

(d) The loan will be repaid within a year.

Preposition of duration: Since, for, during, over, through, throughout etc.

Since, For

This is another set of prepositions that often confuse students. *Since* means from *a point of time in the past* and it should be used with the Present Perfect Tense of the verb.

(a) He has been absent *since* Monday.

(b) It has been raining continuously *since* yesterday.

For is used only when you refer to a period of time and not a point of time.

(a) I have been waiting here *for* two hours.

He has been appointed *for* three years.

During is used with known periods of time such as: during the winter, during the vacation.

(a) Prices had gone up during the Second World War.

(b) We went to Dehradun during the vacations.

Over, Throughout

Over is followed by nouns/noun phrases denoting shorter period of time like *over the weekends, over Sunday* and throughout is used with longer periods of time like *throughout the Middle Ages, throughout the last month.*

(a) We played cricket over the weekend.

(b) Agriculture was the main source of income for the majority of the people throughout the Middle Ages.

'From'

From is used to indicate the time when something starts.

(a) Students will not be allowed in the library from ten in the evening.

From....to/until/ up to is used to express duration.

(a) We waited for you at the university from six/to/until/up to nine in the evening.

Until/ till is used to indicate that a situation continues for some time and then stops.

(a) We worked in the office until twelve o'clock at midnight.

Until/till can also be used to indicate that something did not/ will not happen before a particular time.

(a) The library was not open till 11 o'clock on Sunday morning.

(b) The guests will not arrive until five in the morning.

Preposition of means

By, With

By is used in referring to the doer of an action, to indicate means of transport (without article THE) and means of communication.

(a) He was killed by the thief.

(b) We travelled from Delhi to Amritsar by train.

(c) I received the interview call by fax.

With+ noun phrase is used to express the sense of instrument with which the action is done.

(a) The tiger was shot by me with my new gun.

(b) She opened the door with a key.

Preposition of manner and Role: *like, as*

Manner can be expressed by like

(a) He danced like a possessed man.

As expresses the sense of a role.

(a) She speaks as a lawyer.